

Hippopotamuses

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Mammalia
ORDER	Artiodactyla
FAMILY	Hippopotamidae
SPECIES	2

Members of this family have a semiaquatic lifestyle and are thought to be more closely related to whales than to other even-toed hoofed mammals. They cannot swim, but may remain submerged for over 5 minutes. They move underwater by pushing themselves off the bottom using

their forelimbs. The hippopotamus is abundant, and lives along rivers and lakes in Africa. The smaller, less aquatic pygmy hippopotamus is restricted to swampy forest areas in West Africa—it is endangered due to habitat destruction and hunting.

Anatomy

Hippopotamuses have a long, heavy body with short, surprisingly insubstantial-looking legs. The enormous head features jaws that allow a huge gape (up to 150 degrees) and carry long, tusklike canine and incisor teeth. The nose is wide and covered with sensitive bristles. The tail is short, tufted, and flattened.

Adaptations for life in the water include webbed toes; eyes, ears, and nostrils located at the top of the head (these are often the only part of the animal protruding above water); and the ability to close the nostrils underwater.

The skin is gray with a pinkish tinge on the underside and

around the eyes and skin folds. It is almost hairless in most parts, and extremely thick and fatty. Hippopotamus skin is unusual in that there are no sebaceous glands. Instead, there are mucous glands (which are modified sweat glands) that produce a viscous fluid to keep the skin moist when exposed to air. This fluid, which is pink due to the presence of a red pigment, may also protect against infection and prevent sunburn.

While the hippopotamus weighs about 1½ tons (1.4 tonnes), the pygmy hippopotamus, which has relatively longer legs, a much smaller head, darker skin, and eyes at the side of the head, averages only about 550 lb (250 kg).

Feeding

The hippopotamus moves inland at night to graze, generally following trails—marked by dung piles—that lead to its

feeding grounds. Each night, an individual will eat about 88 lb (40 kg) of grass. The food is digested in a compartmentalized stomach (the fore-stomach contains bacteria that ferments cellulose). Although this system is slow, the hippopotamus requires less food than animals of a similar size because much of its life is spent supported in water. The pygmy hippopotamus eats roots, grasses, shoots, and fallen fruit, although little is known about its feeding habits.

Social groups

The pygmy hippopotamus is usually found in small groups of up to 3. Female common hippopotamuses and their young, however, form groups of usually 10–20 (but sometimes of up to 100) during the day (night-foraging is a solitary affair). They communicate via staccato grunts and deep rumbles that carry some distance in the water. Each group occupies a home range along a section of riverbank or lakeshore, within the territory of a dominant male. This male marks his territory with heaps of dung that he scatters by furiously wagging his tail. Other males enter the territory, but they are tolerated only if they behave submissively and do not attempt to mate. Mating occurs in the water, but the calves are usually born on land.

TERRITORIAL BATTLE

Territorial conflicts between male hippopotamuses are not uncommon, particularly where population densities are high. If, after a period of roaring and ritualized displaying, neither male gives way, a fight will ensue. Using their lower canines as weapons, a battle may last for hours and can result in serious injury.

